

Discharge Information

Lower Spine Disk Surgery

You were in the hospital for surgery on the spinal bones (vertebrae) in your lower back.

This handout tells you and your caregiver what you need to know about your care in the first weeks at home. Ask your doctor or nurse if there are things you do not understand.

Follow-up Appointments

Name of Doctor	Day & Time	Phone Number
1.		
2.		
3.		



Eating Plan

- Eat your usual foods unless your doctor gave you a special eating plan.
- Eat a balance of healthy foods to help your bones heal.
 - Fruits and vegetables have vitamins.
 - Dairy products have calcium.
 - Lean beef, chicken (no skin), pork, fish, and whole grains have protein and phosphorus.
 - Avoid foods with a lot of fat, cholesterol, salt, or sugar.
- Add more fiber to your eating plan to help prevent hard stools (constipation). Fiber is in whole grains, vegetables, and fruits.
- Stay at a healthy weight. Being overweight adds more strain to your back. Ask your doctor what a good weight for you would be.



Activity

- Your doctor and physical therapist will tell you what types of exercises you should do and how often you should do them.
- Keep doing the exercises your therapist taught you in the hospital.
- Avoid activities that make you bend over or lift heavy objects until your doctor tells you it is OK. These include vacuuming, lifting groceries or full garbage bags, and doing laundry.
- Avoid contact sports such as football, martial arts, ice hockey, and wrestling. If you play other sports, ask your doctor when it is safe to begin these again.
- Do not drive or return to work until your doctor says it is OK.



Self-Care

- Keep all doctor appointments. Ask the doctor if all shots (vaccines) are up to date.
- Know who you want called in case of an emergency, like a family member. Keep their contact information in a place it can be found quickly, like a cell phone, wallet, or bag.
- Take care of your wound as you were taught. Only use skin cleansers or lotions on the wound if the doctor tells you to.
- Find ways to relax to cut down pain, such as taking deep breaths or listening to music.
- Prevent blood clots in your legs.
 - Keep your legs propped up while lying down.
 - Avoid sitting for long periods of time. If you do, stretch your legs as much as you can. Do not cross your legs while sitting.
 - Do not wear socks with tight bands that leave marks on your legs.
 - Wear compression stockings every day if your doctor told you to.
 - Take blood thinner medicine if your doctor orders it.

- Reduce your risk of falls. Keep the floor and walkways clear. Wear shoes with nonskid soles. Get up slowly from sitting or lying down.
- If you smoke, you should stop now. Talk to your doctor about ways to help you quit.



Medicines

- When you leave the hospital, you should get:
 - A list of all the medicines you should take
 - Prescriptions for any new medicines
- Take your medicine as your doctor asked you to.
 - Talk to your doctor before you stop taking a medicine.
 - Keep a list of all the medicines you take. Include your prescription medicines, and vitamins, herbs, and medicines you buy at the store.
 - Take the medicine list to every doctor or hospital visit.
 - Get the follow-up tests that your doctor orders.
- To cut down your pain, take the pain medicine before activities that can hurt, such as therapy, exercise, or dressing changes.
- These programs help you pay for prescription medicines if you cannot afford them.
 - NeedyMeds. Go to: www.needymeds.org
 - Medicine Assistance Tool (MAT). Go to: <https://medicineassistancetool.org>



When to Call for Emergency Help

- You have trouble breathing.
- You suddenly start having chest pain.
- Your bandage is soaked with blood.

- You do not have feeling in your legs or feet.
- You feel burning, numbness, tingling, or a cool feeling in your toes or feet.
- You have signs of a blood clot in your leg.
 - Your leg is red and swollen.
 - There is swelling, warmth, and tenderness along a vein in your leg.



When to Call Your Surgeon

- Pain medicine does not help the pain.
- You have a fever over 100.4 or chills.
- You cannot stand up straight.
- You have problems with the wound.
 - The wound changes in color.
 - There is a warm feeling around the wound.
 - The wound opens up.
 - There is bleeding, pus, or a bad smell coming from the wound.
- You fall.



When to Call Your Regular Doctor

- Your stools are very hard, or you have not had any in 3 days (constipation).
- You have a cough that does not stop.
- You have other medical problems.



To Learn More

- American Academy of Orthopaedic Surgeons (AAOS). Go to: www.orthoinfo.org

- National Institutes of Health. Go to: www.smokefree.gov

This information is general in nature and may not apply to you or your condition. Talk to your doctor or nurse about how to best use this information and how to take care of your medical condition. Be sure to ask your doctor or nurse any questions you might have. This information sheet is not intended to provide or replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.

Patient or Caregiver:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Nurse:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Medicine List

Name: _____

[illegible]